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Growth, 14nm chips and taking down Qualcomm: MediaTek talks to Digit

MediaTek, the chief competitor to Qualcomm in the market, has found a very rare chance to dig into the American chipset maker's market lead.

◀ Finbarr Moynihan, General Manager, Corporate Sales International

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▣ Everybody is talking about R&D in India. What's really different about India, from the market side?

FM: I think in some sense it's not that different, while in some senses it's different. If you look at it, India tends to lag behind China. What's interesting is, in India, the percentage of mobile Internet access is higher than anywhere else. It gives India the potential to be very much a mobile first Internet community, which I think creates some interesting use cases.

▣ Is there a difference because of the maturity of the market? Like China is largely considered to be a more mature market than India.

FM: Perhaps. You know, it moves. If you think about the mobile industry, it to some sense started in Europe, with Nokia, Ericsson, Siemens etc. Now, Nokia is part of Microsoft, Ericsson is part of Sony and Europe is more about the infrastructure. The mobile platforms have moved to the west coast with Apple, Google, Microsoft. That's not the whole story, but that's the way it's going. Where next right?

▣ Is India the obvious answer to that?

FM: It seems to be right? It's a big market,

it's a big population, I don't want to say it's a homogenous market, but it's at least one country right? If you think about Africa, Europe, Latin America, the problem is those are not one country. There are so many countries, all with unique import/export duties, government taxes etc. and it's much more fragmented. The only other market that has that kind of scale as a single market is India, I think.

▣ Getting to the chipsets that you make, MediaTek has till now been associated with the more affordable range of mobile phones, do you plan to get into a flagship range?

FM: Yes, absolutely. It's very much a key focus for us. While yes, historically on mobile we've been more associated with entry and mainstream products, the not so well known part of MediaTek is, we also have a very strong business in the home entertainment space. A lot of that capability is now coming into mobiles, like 2K displays, 4K video etc. So we've been able to bring a lot of that technology and integrate it into our mobile platforms. You see us starting with Helio X10, we just announced X20, which brings a whole new set of innovations with deca core, tri-cluster etc. And then the exciting thing is that we start to see brands like HTC, and you'll see more, launching flagship products based on Helio.

▣ What other top brands except HTC are using Helio?

FM: Right now only Chinese brands have announced Helio devices.

▣ But to truly go global, you have to enter the US market right? And for that you need a solid tier I brand, or you're looking at the Chinese manufacturers penetrating the US market?

FM: Both. One of our customers, Alcatel, just launched an LTE phone in the US market, so we're already shipping LTE to the US market. But the US market is a different market. It's a heavily operator subsidised market, but operators are starting to test the limits of device subsidies. They're starting to unbundle the price from the contract. It's early, and isn't a big part of the market, but I think it's inevitable over time. That I think it favours us, because then it becomes the device on its own, with the features and the value proposition.

▣ Yes, they ship in those markets, but like you said, LG is going to launch MediaTek driven devices, but the inexpensive ones. So it's like when an OEM wants its devices to be cheaper, they go with MediaTek.

FM: No I wouldn't say that's the case, I would say it's about the right features at the right power and performance.